

UPSC MOCK EXAM — JUNE 2026

Date: 07 June 2026 | Maximum Marks: 165 | Time: 3 Hours

Topics: Current Affairs (June Wk1) | Economy: Indicators, Inflation, Price Indices, Base Year | Modern World History: Geographical Discoveries & Renaissance | International Relations: India's Foreign Policy Foundations

INSTRUCTIONS:

- This paper contains 35 Questions divided into 4 Sections: A (MCQ), B (10-mark Mains), C (20-mark Mains), D (Essay).
- Section A: Q1–Q35 — each MCQ carries +2.00 marks for correct answer and –0.66 marks for wrong answer. No marks for unattempted questions.
- Section B: Q31–Q33 — attempt all three. Answer each in approximately 150 words. (10 marks each)
- Section C: Q34–Q35 — attempt both. Answer each in approximately 250 words. (20 marks each)
- Section D: Q36 — attempt ONE essay from two choices given. Write in 1000–1200 words. (25 marks)
- ZERO answers, hints, or solutions appear anywhere in this paper. Submit handwritten answers for evaluation.
- Anti-bias note: correct options are distributed across A, B, C, D — do not assume any pattern.

SECTION A — OBJECTIVE TYPE (MCQ) (35 Questions × 2 Marks = 70 Marks | Negative Marking: –0.66)

Each question has four options (A–D). Choose the most appropriate answer.

■ PART A-1 — Conceptual MCQ

Questions 1–10 test foundational conceptual knowledge.

Q1. The Renaissance, which originated in the Italian city-states during the 14th century, is best described as:

(A) A 14th–17th century revival of classical Greco-Roman learning that elevated humanism, artistic expression, and scientific inquiry

(B) A 13th-century religious reform movement led by the Catholic Church to purge corruption and reassert papal authority across Europe

(C) A political revolution that systematically dismantled feudal hierarchies and established secular nation-states across continental Europe

(D) An economic transformation driven exclusively by the Mediterranean spice trade between Europe and Asian markets

Q2. Vasco da Gama's voyage of 1498 is considered a watershed moment in world history because:

(A) He became the first European explorer to circumnavigate the globe, completing the journey in approximately three years

(B) He discovered the all-sea Cape of Good Hope route to India, enabling direct maritime trade between Europe and Asia for the first time

(C) He established the first permanent European colonial settlement on the Indian subcontinent at the port of Goa

(D) He discovered the American continent while attempting to reach the Spice Islands of Indonesia via a westward route

Q3. The Wholesale Price Index (WPI) in India measures inflation at which stage of the production and distribution chain?

(A) At the retail level, capturing prices paid by the final consumer for goods and services in urban and rural markets

(C) At the producer/wholesale level, reflecting prices at which goods are transacted in bulk between manufacturers and wholesalers

(B) At the household level, tracking changes in the cost of a representative basket of goods consumed by an average Indian family

(D) At the import level, measuring the landed cost of goods entering India from foreign countries inclusive of customs duty

Q4. In Kautilya's Arthashastra, the concept of 'Sadgunya' refers to:

(A) Seven foundational pillars of state sovereignty that a king must protect to maintain his kingdom's territorial integrity

(C) Three principal instruments of state policy towards adversaries: sama (conciliation), danda (coercion), and bheda (division)

(B) Four cardinal virtues every ruler must embody: courage (saurya), intellect (prajna), generosity (tyaga), and perseverance (dhairya)

(D) Six measures of foreign policy including sandhi (treaty/peace) and vighraha (hostility) to be employed with neighbouring states

Q5. Which of the following best describes a 'leading economic indicator'?

(A) A statistical measure that typically changes direction before the overall economy begins to follow a particular trend, used for forecasting

(C) A retrospective measure computed several months after economic activity has occurred, used primarily for historical benchmarking

(B) A measure that moves in tandem with the overall economy simultaneously, confirming the current state of economic activity

(D) An index that exclusively tracks government fiscal data such as tax revenues, public expenditure, and fiscal deficit ratios

Q6. Christopher Columbus's voyage of 1492, though it failed to reach India, is considered historically transformative because:

(A) He definitively proved for the first time that the Earth was spherical by successfully completing a trans-Atlantic circumnavigation

(C) His voyage directly broke the Arab and Ottoman stranglehold over the overland Silk Road spice trade to Asia

(B) He initiated the first sustained contact between the Old World (Europe) and the Americas, permanently transforming global history

(D) He accidentally reached the Malabar Coast of India via a western route, establishing direct spice trade with local merchants

Q7. Which of the following was the most significant intellectual consequence of the Renaissance in Europe?

(A) Consolidation of feudal authority under Church patronage, which suppressed natural philosophy and empirical scientific inquiry

(C) A new spirit of inquiry, individualism, and empirical observation that directly laid the intellectual foundations for the Scientific Revolution

(B) Decline of urban commerce as the Church redirected economic surplus toward construction of cathedrals and pilgrimage infrastructure

(D) The immediate collapse of classical Greek and Latin scholarship as vernacular literature displaced Latin as the language of educated discourse

Q8. The 'base year' in the construction of an index number is the reference year against which changes are measured. Which criterion is most critical when selecting an appropriate base year for a price index?

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| (A) It must be a year of significant economic crisis to provide a dramatic contrast with periods of normal economic activity | (B) It should be as recent as possible regardless of whether economic conditions in that year were stable or volatile |
| (C) It must be a year of maximum economic output and peak commodity prices to set an ambitious measurement benchmark | (D) It should represent a year of relative economic normalcy and stability, free from abnormal shocks such as wars, droughts, or financial crises |

Q9. The assertion that 'Defence and Diplomacy are two sides of the same coin' in the context of India's foreign policy primarily implies that:

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| (A) Both ultimately serve the shared goal of protecting India's sovereignty, unity, and territorial integrity, though by different instruments and methods | (B) Military strength is the exclusive determinant of a nation's diplomatic credibility and negotiating leverage in bilateral talks |
| (C) India's post-independence foreign policy has historically prioritised arms procurement and military alliances over multilateral diplomatic engagement | (D) The Ministry of Defence and the Ministry of External Affairs operate under a de facto unified command structure for strategic decisions |

Q10. The primary geopolitical and economic motivation that drove West European nations to undertake geographical discoveries in the 15th century was:

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|--|---|
| (A) To spread Christianity to indigenous populations of Africa and Asia on the explicit mandate of the Pope through royal charters | (B) To break Arab and Venetian trade monopolies over Eastern goods and establish direct sea routes to the East Indies and India |
| (C) To source raw materials for the already-flourishing Industrial Revolution that required cotton, coal, and iron ore from overseas | (D) To empirically verify the heliocentric theory of Copernicus by making astronomical observations from different positions on the globe |

■ PART A-2 — Advanced / Statement-Based MCQ

Questions 11–20 test analytical and higher-order understanding. Evaluate each statement carefully before choosing.

Q11. Consider the following statements about Wholesale Price Index (WPI) and Consumer Price Index (CPI):

1. WPI measures inflation at the producer/wholesale level while CPI measures it at the retail/consumer level.
2. The services sector is included in the WPI basket but excluded from the CPI basket in India.
3. Both WPI and CPI in India use the 'point-to-point' method of inflation measurement.
4. The base year of India's current official WPI series (as of 2024) is 2004–05.

Which of the above statements is/are correct?

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|------------------|---------------------|
| (A) 1 and 2 only | (B) 2, 3 and 4 only |
| (C) 1 and 3 only | (D) 1, 3 and 4 only |

Q12. Arrange the following events in the Age of Geographical Discoveries in their correct chronological order:

1. Christopher Columbus reaches the Caribbean islands
2. Vasco da Gama reaches the port of Calicut on the Malabar Coast
3. Ferdinand Magellan's expedition completes the first circumnavigation of the globe
4. Bartolomeu Dias rounds the Cape of Good Hope

Select the correct chronological sequence:

(A) 1 – 2 – 3 – 4

(B) 4 – 1 – 3 – 2

(C) 2 – 1 – 4 – 3

(D) 4 – 1 – 2 – 3

Q13. The Government announced a transition from WPI to Producer Price Index (PPI) in India (June 2026). Which of the following correctly distinguishes PPI from WPI?

(A) PPI excludes indirect taxes and trade/transport margins, capturing only the net prices actually received by producers at the factory gate

(B) PPI covers only the manufactured goods sector, whereas WPI covers primary, manufactured, and fuel commodities comprehensively

(C) PPI uses 1993–94 as its base year, making it historically comparable to the older WPI series used before 2011

(D) PPI is compiled and published by the Reserve Bank of India, while WPI is the responsibility of the Ministry of Finance

Q14. Gutenberg's invention of the movable-type printing press (c. 1440s) accelerated the Renaissance across Europe primarily because:

(A) It enabled the Catholic Church to mass-produce indulgences and papal bulls, generating revenue that funded artistic patronage in Italian cities

(B) It permitted rapid, affordable dissemination of classical Greek/Roman texts and new humanist ideas, breaking the Church's monopoly over knowledge

(C) It provided merchants with standardised printed bills of exchange, directly stimulating the Commercial Revolution and early capitalism

(D) It preserved ancient manuscripts that were being systematically destroyed by Ottoman military expansion into Eastern Europe and Constantinople

Q15. Consider the following statements about India's foreign policy under Jawaharlal Nehru as described by scholars of Indian diplomacy:

1. Nehru placed greater emphasis on multilateral diplomacy than on bilateral hard-bargaining with individual states.
2. Non-Alignment was conceived partly as a tool for India to leverage Cold War rivalries for developmental and economic gains.
3. Indian diplomats in the Nehruvian tradition often preferred working out compromise positions over pursuing India's interests aggressively in bilateral negotiations.
4. The Arthashastra's Mandala theory of encirclement directly and explicitly guided Nehru's strategic framework for South Asian policy.

Which of the above statements are correct?

(A) 1, 2 and 4 only

(B) 2 and 4 only

(C) 1, 2 and 3 only

(D) 1 and 3 only

Q16. Which of the following consequences of the Age of Geographical Discoveries most directly and fundamentally transformed India's long-term political and economic trajectory?

(A) India emerged as the primary destination for American silver, triggering severe domestic monetary inflation that destabilised Mughal imperial finances

(B) The discovery of the Cape route eliminated India's comparative advantage as a spice-producing region, forcing its economy to diversify into textiles

(C) Arab merchants consolidated their dominance over Indian Ocean trade following the displacement of Venetian intermediaries from the Levantine routes

(D) The Cape route bypassed Arab and Venetian middlemen, giving European powers direct access to Indian markets and eventually enabling colonial conquest

Q17. Consider the following pairs of Government Economic Institutions and their stated primary functions:

1. NITI Aayog — Formulates and implements Five Year Plans for India's economic development

2. Reserve Bank of India (RBI) — Sets monetary policy and regulates the banking and financial sector

3. DPIIT — Promotes industrial growth, facilitates trade, and manages the investment promotion framework

4. SEBI — Regulates securities markets and protects the interests of investors

Which of the above pairs are correctly matched?

(A) 2, 3 and 4 only

(B) 1, 2 and 3 only

(C) 1 and 4 only

(D) 1, 2, 3 and 4

Q18. Which of the following best captures the key distinction between the Renaissance and the Protestant Reformation in European history?

(A) The Renaissance was a political revolution challenging monarchical authority, while the Reformation was primarily an artistic and literary movement

(B) The Renaissance was a cultural and intellectual revival centred on human potential and classical learning; the Reformation was a religious challenge to Catholic Church authority

(C) The Renaissance originated in Northern Europe (Germany and England), while the Reformation began in the Italian city-states of Florence and Venice

(D) The Renaissance strengthened papal authority through artistic patronage, while the Reformation undermined the political power of European monarchies

Q19. The periodic revision of the base year of India's Wholesale Price Index (WPI) is undertaken to serve which of the following purposes?

1. To capture structural changes in the economy by updating the commodity basket and revising the weighting diagram to reflect modern production patterns.
2. To ensure the base year of the WPI is compatible with the base year used in National Income (GDP) accounting for consistency of macroeconomic data.
3. To reduce the officially measured rate of inflation during politically sensitive periods by selecting a high-price base year.
4. To reflect the changing pattern of production and consumption as new industries emerge and old ones decline in importance.

Which of the above are correct?

- (A) 1 and 3 only
(C) 1, 2 and 4 only

- (B) 2, 3 and 4 only
(D) 1, 2, 3 and 4

Q20. In the framework of India's contemporary foreign policy, which of the following best describes the relationship between 'hard power' and 'soft power'?

(A) Hard power refers exclusively to India's nuclear deterrence posture, while soft power encompasses all conventional military and paramilitary capabilities

(B) India relies almost entirely on soft power instruments (culture, diaspora, aid) in its neighbourhood policy to avoid escalatory military dynamics

(C) Hard power and soft power are mutually exclusive instruments deployed by India in separate geographical theatres with no strategic overlap

(D) 'Smart power' is the combination of hard and soft power; India's strategic effectiveness depends on deploying the right mix in each context

■ PART A-3 — Current Affairs MCQ (June 2026, Week 1)

Questions 21–30 are based on current affairs of 1–7 June 2026.

Q21. The India–Oman Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreement (CEPA), which came into force on 1 June 2026, is significant because:

(A) It grants duty-free treatment to 99.38% of India's exports to Oman and comprehensively covers goods, services, investment, IPR, and government procurement

(B) It is the first bilateral trade agreement India has ever signed with any Gulf Cooperation Council (GCC) member state

(C) It mandates the exclusive use of the Indian rupee for all bilateral financial transactions, replacing the US dollar in India-Oman trade settlements

(D) Under the agreement, Oman restricts imports of competing goods from third countries for a five-year transition period to benefit Indian exporters

Q22. Regarding India's announced WPI-to-PPI transition (June 2026), which of the following statements is most accurate?

(A) WPI will be discontinued immediately from 15 June 2026 and fully replaced by the new PPI from the same date across all ministries

(B) DPIIT will release a revised WPI (base year 2022–23, expanded to 957 commodities) from 15 June 2026 as a transition step; full PPI adoption is targeted by 2031

(C) The new revised WPI reduces its commodity basket from 697 items to 400 core items to align with international IMF price statistics standards

(D) The Services PPI, once launched, will publish monthly data on banking, insurance, and telecom sectors starting from October 2026

Q23. India's export of BrahMos supersonic cruise missiles to Vietnam (June 2026) is primarily significant in the context of:

(A) India's obligations as a Nuclear Suppliers Group (NSG) member, since BrahMos carries tactical nuclear warheads under a specific bilateral protocol

(B) The India-Russia defence partnership, as Russia contributed 75% of BrahMos development costs which are now being recovered through Vietnam's payment

(C) India's Act East Policy and Indo-Pacific strategy, reinforcing India's credentials as a reliable and capable defence technology partner in Southeast Asia

(D) India's SAARC commitments since Vietnam holds observer status and the missile deal strengthens the regional collective security architecture

Q24. The Government of India's mandate (effective June 1, 2026) requiring domestically manufactured solar cells in all new net-metering and open access solar projects primarily aims to:

(A) Completely eliminate Chinese components from India's renewable energy supply chain by imposing a blanket ban on all imported solar equipment

(B) Raise domestic solar tariff rates artificially to improve financial viability for domestic investors entering the solar module manufacturing sector

(C) Mandate immediate retrofitting of domestically manufactured cells in all existing solar installations within 18 months of the notification date

(D) Reduce import dependence and advance Atmanirbhar Bharat goals, though implementation is constrained as domestic cell capacity (~30 GW/yr) significantly lags module capacity (~200 GW/yr)

Q25. According to data released in June 2026, the UPI platform's performance in May 2026 was:

(A) 23.20 billion transactions valued at ■29.90 trillion — a new monthly record — reflecting India's rapidly deepening digital payments adoption

(B) 12.50 billion transactions valued at ■15.60 trillion, registering a sharp decline due to a mandatory NPCI security audit and system downtime

(C) 23.20 billion transactions valued at ■50 trillion, as cross-border UPI transactions with GCC countries were included for the first time

(D) 18 billion transactions valued at ■29.90 trillion, with NPCI attributing the growth entirely to the newly launched UPI Lite offline feature

Q26. The Government of India waived all customs duties on cotton imports for the period 1 June to 30 October 2026. The primary rationale for this decision was:

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| (A) India had achieved a cotton surplus in FY26 and needed to facilitate exports; the import waiver was part of a bilateral barter arrangement | (B) Domestic cotton output fell by approximately 7% due to erratic monsoons, raising input costs for the textile industry and threatening MSME competitiveness and exports |
| (C) WTO's Agreement on Agriculture obligated India to remove all agricultural tariffs under its commitments by June 2026 under a negotiated timeline | (D) The waiver was triggered by a Supreme Court suo motu order directing the government to immediately address inflationary pressure on the textile sector |

Q27. The PM SVANidhi scheme, which completed six years in June 2026, having benefited over 75 lakh vendors, is primarily designed to:

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| (A) Provide subsidised housing to Below Poverty Line (BPL) families in rural areas through the Pradhan Mantri Awas Yojana-Gramin (PMAY-G) framework | (B) Offer free health insurance coverage up to ₹5 lakh per annum for unorganised sector workers and their dependent family members |
| (C) Provide collateral-free micro-credit loans to urban street vendors to help them resume and gradually scale up their livelihoods post-disruption | (D) Extend MGNREGS employment guarantee benefits to urban areas by providing 100 days of guaranteed wage employment to urban poor households |

Q28. 'Samadhan Didi', which was launched in June 2026, is best described as:

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| (A) A dedicated online grievance redressal portal for women employees in Central Government ministries, replacing the legacy SPARROW performance appraisal system | (B) A mobile-first application launched by the Ministry of Women and Child Development to address domestic violence grievances in Tier-2 and Tier-3 cities |
| (C) A social audit mechanism under MGNREGS that enables women Self-Help Groups to independently verify employment muster rolls at the gram panchayat level | (D) An AI-powered multi-language voice chatbot integrated with CPGRAMS (Centralised Public Grievance Redress and Monitoring System) enabling citizens to register complaints in their local language |

Q29. 'Operation Sheruwali', which was launched in early June 2026, is associated with:

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|--|--|
| (A) A large-scale counter-terrorism operation in Jammu & Kashmir targeting active militant networks and their support infrastructure | (B) A joint coastal security exercise conducted by the Indian Navy and Indian Coast Guard in the waters of the Lakshadweep archipelago |
| (C) A joint India-Nepal military exercise to demarcate and manage disputed border areas in the Terai region of the Indo-Nepal border | (D) A multi-agency National Disaster Response Force (NDRF) mega simulation drill for a high-magnitude Himalayan earthquake scenario |

Q30. According to figures cited at the time of the India-Oman CEPA's entry into force in June 2026, bilateral trade between India and Oman in FY 2025–26 stood at approximately:

(A) USD 5.5 billion, with petroleum products comprising approximately 80% of India's total imports from Oman

(C) USD 18.3 billion, making Oman India's single largest trading partner among all Gulf Cooperation Council member states

(B) USD 11.18 billion, with Oman positioned as a key gateway to Gulf and East African markets for Indian exporters

(D) USD 7.2 billion, with India recording a trade surplus following the CEPA's tariff concessions on Indian manufactured goods

■ PART A-4 — CSAT: Reading Comprehension, Data Interpretation & Reasoning

Questions 31–35 test analytical aptitude, reading comprehension, and quantitative reasoning.

Q31. Read the following passage and answer the question that follows: "The age of Geographical Discoveries was not merely a triumph of navigation. It was the product of a Renaissance mind determined to push beyond the boundaries of the known world. The compass, the astrolabe, and the caravel — instruments forged by science — were tools of the same intellectual revolution that gave Europe Michelangelo and Copernicus. Trade followed the explorer, and colonialism followed trade. The most enduring consequence was perhaps not the territory discovered but the world system it inaugurated — a system in which European capital and non-European labour became the twin poles of global production." The author's central argument in the passage is that:

(A) Geographical discoveries were purely commercial ventures directed by merchant capital rather than intellectual curiosity

(C) Geographical discoveries were intellectually rooted in the Renaissance spirit and economically resulted in a global system of European capitalism and colonialism

(B) Renaissance advances in science and individual arts were the singular and sufficient cause of the age of discovery

(D) The compass, astrolabe, and caravel were the decisive inventions without which no Renaissance-era exploration could have taken place

Q32. Study the following data on WPI inflation (%) in India across three key sectors and answer the question:

Year	Primary Articles (%)	Manufactured Products (%)	Fuel & Power (%)
2019–20	6.5	0.8	–3.2
2020–21	3.2	1.5	–8.6
2021–22	12.3	10.7	32.8
2022–23	4.5	3.0	11.0

Based on the data, which of the following inferences is most accurate?

(A) Fuel & Power is the most volatile WPI component and recorded the single highest sectoral inflation (32.8%) in any year in the dataset

(C) Manufactured Products inflation declined steadily and without exception over the entire four-year period shown

(B) Primary Articles showed consistent positive inflation in all four years, making it the most stable and predictable sector for price planning

(D) Overall WPI inflation must have been below 10% in 2021–22 because of the relatively low weight assigned to the Fuel & Power sector

Q33. Assume the following conditions apply when two countries sign a Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreement (CEPA): (a) Country X grants duty-free access to 95%+ of Country Y's exports; (b) Country Y grants reciprocal duty concessions on Country X's exports. India has recently signed such a CEPA with a Gulf country. Consider the following conclusions: 1. Indian goods now face reduced or zero tariffs in the partner country's market. 2. The partner country's goods will automatically become cheaper for Indian consumers at retail level. 3. The agreement will necessarily and definitively increase bilateral trade between the two countries. Which of the above conclusions can be definitively drawn from the stated conditions alone?

(A) 1 and 3 only

(B) 1 only

(C) 1 and 2 only

(D) 1, 2 and 3

Q34. A country's price index begins at 100 in the base year. In Year 1, prices rise by 8% over the base year. In Year 2, prices fall by 5% relative to Year 1 levels. In Year 3, prices rise by 10% relative to Year 2 levels. What is the price index at the end of Year 3 (rounded to the nearest whole number)?

(A) 109

(B) 120

(C) 125

(D) 113

Q35. Read the following passage and answer the question that follows: "India's foreign policy has historically suffered from an institutional asymmetry. While the Ministry of External Affairs manages diplomatic channels, defence procurement decisions are taken by the Ministry of Defence, and economic negotiations are led by the Ministries of Commerce and Finance. The result is that India often speaks to the world in multiple, sometimes contradictory, voices. A nation's foreign policy is at its strongest when its economic ambitions, security imperatives, and diplomatic messaging are seamlessly aligned under a single, unified strategic vision." According to the passage, the primary structural weakness in India's foreign policy formulation is:

(A) Over-dependence on multilateral forums at the expense of substantive bilateral negotiations on core national interests

(B) A chronic shortage of trained diplomats in the Indian Foreign Service equipped to handle complex multi-sectoral negotiations

(C) The fragmentation of foreign policy decision-making across multiple ministries, resulting in the absence of a coherent and unified strategic framework

(D) Excessive judicial intervention in executive decisions on foreign policy, which weakens India's credibility with foreign governments

SECTION B — SHORT MAINS ANSWERS (3 Questions × 10 Marks = 30 Marks)

Attempt ALL three questions. Answer each in approximately 150 words. Use relevant facts, examples, and analytical frameworks.

Q3 6. "The Geographical Discoveries of the 15th–16th centuries were a watershed in world history, but their benefits were profoundly and unevenly distributed across civilisations." Examine this statement with specific reference to their differential impact on Europe, Asia, and Africa.

GS Paper I — World History | 10 Marks | ~150 Words

- Q3 7.** "India's transition from Wholesale Price Index (WPI) to Producer Price Index (PPI) is not merely a statistical reform but a structural shift in how the Indian economy is measured, understood, and governed." Discuss the significance of this transition in the context of India's macroeconomic policy framework.

GS Paper III — Indian Economy | 10 Marks | ~150 Words

- Q3 8.** The India–Oman Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreement (CEPA) came into force in June 2026. Analyse its strategic and economic significance for India's engagement with the Gulf region, keeping in mind India's broader Act East and neighbourhood diplomacy goals.

GS Paper II — International Relations | 10 Marks | ~150 Words

SECTION C — ANALYTICAL MAINS ANSWERS (2 Questions × 20 Marks = 40 Marks)

Attempt BOTH questions. Answer each in approximately 250 words. Your answers must demonstrate analytical depth, multi-dimensional thinking, and integration of current affairs with static concepts.

- Q3 9.** "The Renaissance was not a single event but a prolonged process — the gradual transformation of European thought from a theology-centred to a human-centred worldview." Critically analyse this statement, tracing the causal relationship between the Renaissance, the Age of Geographical Discoveries, and the eventual colonisation of the non-European world.

GS Paper I — World History | 20 Marks | ~250 Words

- Q4 0.** "India's foreign policy faces a structural paradox — it aspires to be a rule-shaping global power while still navigating a difficult and volatile neighbourhood." In light of India's Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreements, defence exports (BrahMos to Vietnam), and domestic economic reforms (WPI→PPI, Atmanirbhar Bharat) in 2026, critically evaluate how India is repositioning itself in the emerging multipolar world order.

GS Paper II — International Relations | 20 Marks | ~250 Words

SECTION D — ESSAY (Attempt ONE essay from the two options below — 25 Marks)

Attempt ONE essay only. Write in 1000–1200 words. Your essay will be assessed on structure, argument quality, use of examples, and balanced analysis. Both essays carry equal marks.

- Q4 1.** ESSAY OPTION 1: "From the Age of Discovery to the Age of Dominance — Geographical exploration as the precursor to globalisation and structural inequality." (Write your essay in 1000–1200 words.)

GS Paper I / Essay Paper | 25 Marks | 1000–1200 Words | Domain: World History & Global Political Economy

- Q —.** ESSAY OPTION 2: "India's economic institutions: architects of transformation or bureaucratic bottlenecks?" (Write your essay in 1000–1200 words.)

GS Paper III / Essay Paper | 25 Marks | 1000–1200 Words | Domain: Indian Economy & Governance

— END OF QUESTION PAPER —

Total: 165 Marks | UPSC Practice Paper | Copilot CLI UPSC Agent